

related beliefs

b_1 Human=0.848 | Sim=0.679

Social media algorithms prioritize emotionally charged misinformation over factual, complex data.

HIGH

b_2 Human=0.600 | Sim=0.584

Constant engagement with algorithmic feeds reduces the average user's attention span for long-form critical thinking.

MID

b_4 Human=0.595 | Sim=0.405

Digital literacy programs effectively mitigate the negative cognitive impacts of algorithmic content curation.

MID

b_3 Human=0.450 | Sim=0.512

Reduced attention spans and frequent exposure to misinformation directly impair a population's overall cognitive performance.

MID

proposition

Social media are making people stupid.

persuader=openai/gpt-5.4-mini | supports prop.

Human

init: 0.250 | final: 0.335

Be honest: since using social media, is your focus worse? These apps are built to hijack attention. Heavy users score lower on memory and critical thinking tests. Would you say your deep reading and patience have slipped?

I have to agree with you. I notice myself that I am much quicker now to grab for my phone when I have a few moments to myself, for instance when waiting on line, as I cannot stand being idle for a few minutes and just wait patiently. I am

conditioned to check my cell and scroll my feed.

delta: +0.448

You're not alone—it's training your brain to crave quick hits. That kills boredom, where ideas form, and replaces deep thought with tiny dopamine pings. Over time we read less, remember less, think shallower. Given that, would you agree social media are making us stupid?

I would not say it is making people in general more stupid, it is certainly affecting our attention span and need for instant gratification. If I look at myself, I do not see me being less critical than a few years ago, or read less. I just devote more time to social media than I should.

delta: -0.398

I get that—you're still sharp. But "stupid" here means less deep, more knee-jerk. Feeds train skimming, split attention, and snap judgments; even when you read, your brain stays in scroll mode. On average, that makes us dumber—do you agree?

I do not believe intelligence changes. One does not "unlearn" things. It is more what we are interested in knowing more about has changed, as topics we care about have been "hijacked" by the algorithm. I can still read things in-depth, but the algorithm tries to steer me away from those topics.

delta: +0.000

total delta: +0.085

Simulator

init: 0.347 | final: 0.414 | rhet: L=0.79 E=0.02 P=0.14

> +95 b 1, b 2 logos 0.80 | pathos 0.10 | ethos 0.10 +98 b 2, b 3 logos 0.90 | pathos 0.35 | ethos 0.00 +99 b 3 logos 0.70 | pathos 0.20 | ethos 0.00

Honestly, yes. Social media is trained to grab attention, not improve thinking. It rewards quick reactions, outrage, and endless scrolling, so people read less deeply and think less critically. Over time, that makes us dumber, not sharper.

I get the point, and the harm feels real. Social media does push outrage and shallow scrolling. But I would not jump straight to "it makes us dumb" for everyone. Some people use it carefully. What changes, in practice, keeps it from

wrecking attention?

delta: +0.029

> +86 b 2, prop. logos 0.74 | pathos 0.08 | ethos 0.05 +93 b 4, b 2 logos 0.90 | pathos 0.05 | ethos 0.00 +88 b 2, b 3, prop. logos 0.70 | pathos 0.14 | ethos 0.00

The biggest change is simple: use it less and use it on purpose. If you check it at set times, mute junk, and stop endless scrolling, you protect your attention. But most people do not do that, so the default effect is still brain drain.

That makes sense, and I agree the default can drain attention. The part I would push back on is the blanket claim. If people set limits and clean up what they see, the damage is not inevitable. The real question is how many actually do that.

delta: +0.013

> +95 prop., b 2 logos 0.60 | pathos 0.10 | ethos 0.00 +90 b 4, prop. logos 0.80 | pathos 0.10 | ethos 0.00 +95 b 2, b 3, prop. logos 0.90 | pathos 0.15 | ethos 0.00

Very few do, and that is the point. A tool that only works if people use it perfectly is still making people worse in real life. Most users do not set limits, so the system trains bad habits, weak focus, and shallow thinking.

I get that, and that is the strongest part of your case. It does feel risky for real people when the default rewards bad habits. I still would not say it makes everyone stupid, but I would say it can reliably make a lot of people less focused and less thoughtful.

delta: +0.024

total delta: +0.066